NEXT ENGINEER · _SHEERAT_

Introduction to Women's and Gender Studies

BOE079

One-day revision notes: definitions, solved examples, code and important questions

Program: B.Tech | **Branches:** ALL | **Semester:** 7 | **Credits:** 3 | **L-T-P:** 3-0-0

Scheme: AKTU B.Tech 4th year, Open Elective-II, 2025-26 onwards

UNIT 1 Women and Society

UNIT 2 Feminist Theory

UNIT 3 Women's Movement

UNIT 4 Gender Roles and Psychology of Sex

UNIT 5 Gender and Representation

Original revision notes written for the AKTU syllabus. Every unit has the same parts:

1. **2-mark definitions**: short answers you can write word for word in Section A.
2. **Core concepts**: theories, thinkers, movements and laws, arranged in tables you can reproduce.
3. **Examples and comparisons**: short cases from India and the world to quote in long answers.
4. **Key points to remember**: names, dates and laws.
5. **Important questions**: the long questions to prepare, with what your answer must contain.

How to use these notes the day before the paper

- **Morning (3 hours):** Unit 1 (sex and gender, institutions, theories of gender construction, sexism, androcentrism, patriarchy, public-private divide, sexual division of labour, patriarchy in institutions and textbooks) and Unit 2 (liberal, radical, Marxist, socialist, cultural, eco, postcolonial and postmodern feminism, waves of feminism).
- **Afternoon (3 hours):** Unit 3 (women in the Industrial Revolution, Seneca Falls 1848, suffrage movement to 1920, social reform in India, women's organizations, Uniform Civil Code and the Shah Bano case, Dalit women) and Unit 4 (gender roles and attitudes, gender differences, mental health, trauma and violence, sexual harassment and laws).
- **Evening (2 hours):** Unit 5 (gender in print, electronic media, films, advertisements and serials, stereotypes, women in literature). Then the "Last-hour checklist".
- **In the exam:** name the thinker and the book, give the year, and connect the theory to an Indian example. Keep a balanced, analytical tone.

AKTU paper pattern (theory, 70 marks, 3 hours): Section A has 7 short questions of 2 marks, all compulsory (14). Section B has 5 questions of 7 marks, attempt any 3 (21). Section C has 5 questions (one per unit), each with two parts, attempt one part of each, 7 marks each (35). Every unit gets its own Section C question, so do not skip any unit.

UNIT 1 Women and Society

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Sex:** the biological categories (female, male, intersex) based on chromosomes, hormones and reproductive anatomy.
- **Gender:** the socially and culturally constructed roles, behaviours, expectations and identities associated with being a woman, man or other gender in a society.
- **Gender identity:** a person's internal sense of their own gender, which may or may not match the sex assigned at birth.
- **Socialization:** the process by which people learn the norms, values and roles of their society, including gender roles.
- **Sexism:** prejudice, stereotyping or discrimination based on sex, especially against women.
- **Androcentrism:** treating the male experience as the norm or centre and the female as a deviation (for example, medical research historically based on male bodies).
- **Patriarchy:** a social system in which men hold primary power and dominate in political leadership, moral authority, social privilege and control of property, and in the family fathers hold authority over women and children.
- **Public-private dichotomy:** the division of social life into the "public" sphere (work, politics, economy, associated with men) and the "private" sphere (home, family, care, associated with women).
- **Sexual division of labour:** the assignment of different tasks to men and women on the basis of sex, such as paid work for men and unpaid domestic and care work for women.
- **Unpaid care work:** cooking, cleaning, child and elder care done without pay, mostly by women.

💡 Core concepts

Sex vs gender

Sex	Gender
Biological	Social and cultural
Largely fixed at birth	Learned and changes across time and cultures
Female, male, intersex	Femininity, masculinity, non-binary identities
Example: women can give birth	Example: "women should do the cooking"

Simone de Beauvoir (The Second Sex, 1949): "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman" — gender is made by society. Ann Oakley (Sex, Gender and Society, 1972) popularized the sex/gender distinction in sociology.

Gender-shaping institutions: family (division of chores, son preference), education (curriculum, teacher expectations, subject choices), religion (rules and roles), media (stereotypes), state and law (property, marriage and personal laws), economy and workplace (pay gap, occupational segregation), peer groups.

Theories of gender construction

Theory	Key idea	Thinkers
Biological determinism	Differences come from biology (hormones, brain)	Criticized for ignoring culture
Social learning theory	Gender learned by reward, punishment and imitation	Albert Bandura, Walter Mischel
Cognitive development theory	Children actively build gender concepts (gender constancy)	Lawrence Kohlberg
Gender schema theory	Children develop mental schemas of masculine and feminine and organize information by them	Sandra Bem (1981)
Social construction	Gender is created through social interaction and institutions ("doing gender")	West and Zimmerman (1987)
Performativity	Gender is produced through repeated acts and performance, not an inner essence	Judith Butler, Gender Trouble (1990)

Patriarchy and its theories

- **Radical feminist:** patriarchy is the most basic form of oppression, rooted in men's control of women's bodies and sexuality (Kate Millett, Sexual Politics, 1970; Shulamith Firestone, The Dialectic of Sex, 1970).
- **Marxist:** women's oppression comes from private property and class; the family serves capitalism (Friedrich Engels, The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State, 1884).
- **Dual systems (socialist):** patriarchy and capitalism work together (Heidi Hartmann, 1979).
- **Sylvia Walby (Theorizing Patriarchy, 1990):** six structures: household production, paid work, the state, male violence, sexuality, cultural institutions; private patriarchy (in the home) shifting to public patriarchy (in employment and the state).
- **Gerda Lerner (The Creation of Patriarchy, 1986):** patriarchy is a historical creation, not natural.
- **Brahmanical patriarchy (Uma Chakravarti, 1993):** in India, caste and gender are linked; control of women's sexuality maintains caste purity.

Patriarchal practices in institutions and textbooks: family (son preference, dowry, control of mobility), workplace (glass ceiling, pay gap), politics (low representation), religion (exclusion from rituals), law (historically unequal inheritance), textbooks (women shown as mothers and nurses, men as doctors and leaders; fewer female characters; male pronouns as default). NCERT and NCF reviews have tried to remove gender bias from textbooks.

Examples and comparisons

Example 1: Gender socialization at home. A girl is given a doll and a kitchen set and asked to help her mother; her brother gets a cricket bat and a car and is not asked to do chores. Over time both see these roles as "natural". This is social learning, gender schema and the sexual division of labour at work.

Example 2: Textbook bias. A mathematics problem says "Ramesh earns ₹500 a day and his wife Sita buys vegetables for ₹120". Repeated images like this teach that men earn and women spend, even in a maths book.

Key points to remember

- Sex = biological; gender = social (de Beauvoir 1949, Oakley 1972).
- Institutions: family, education, religion, media, state, economy.
- Theories: social learning, cognitive, gender schema (Bem), social construction, performativity (Butler 1990).
- Patriarchy: radical, Marxist (Engels 1884), dual systems (Hartmann), Walby's six structures, Lerner, Brahmanical patriarchy (Chakravarti).
- Public-private dichotomy; sexual division of labour; unpaid care work.

⭐ Important questions

1. Distinguish between sex and gender. Explain how institutions shape gender.
2. Explain the theories of gender construction.
3. Explain sexism and androcentrism with examples.
4. What is patriarchy? Explain the theories of patriarchy.
5. Explain the public-private dichotomy and the sexual division of labour. How is patriarchy reflected in institutions and textbooks?

NEXT ENGI
sheerat

UNIT 2 Feminist Theory

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Feminism:** a range of social movements and ideologies that aim to define and achieve political, economic, personal and social equality of the sexes.
- **Liberal feminism:** seeks equality through legal and political reform within existing systems: equal rights, education and opportunities.
- **Radical feminism:** sees patriarchy as the root of women's oppression and seeks to transform society, including family and sexuality; "the personal is political".
- **Marxist feminism:** sees women's oppression as rooted in capitalism and class; ending capitalism ends women's oppression.
- **Socialist feminism:** combines Marxist and radical ideas: both capitalism and patriarchy oppress women.
- **Cultural feminism:** celebrates distinct female qualities (care, cooperation, nurturing) and values women's culture.
- **Ecofeminism:** links the domination of women and the domination of nature, arguing that both come from patriarchal thinking.
- **Postcolonial feminism:** criticizes Western feminism for ignoring the experiences of women in formerly colonized countries and for treating them as one group of victims.
- **Postmodern feminism:** questions fixed categories like "woman" and sees gender as constructed through language and discourse.
- **Intersectionality:** the idea that gender combines with race, caste, class, religion, sexuality and disability to create distinct experiences of discrimination (Kimberlé Crenshaw, 1989).

💡 Core concepts

Rise of feminism: Enlightenment ideas of reason and rights; Mary Wollstonecraft's "A Vindication of the Rights of Woman" (1792) argued that women are not naturally inferior but lack education; John Stuart Mill and Harriet Taylor Mill, "The Subjection of Women" (1869); industrialization brought women into factories and public life; anti-slavery and reform movements.

Feminist schools compared

School	Cause of oppression	Solution	Key thinkers and works
Liberal	Unequal laws, lack of opportunity	Legal reform, education, equal rights	Wollstonecraft (1792), J. S. Mill (1869), Betty Friedan, The Feminine Mystique (1963)
Radical	Patriarchy, male control of bodies and sexuality	Transform society, women's spaces, end patriarchy	Kate Millett (1970), Shulamith Firestone (1970), Andrea Dworkin
Marxist	Capitalism and private property	Socialist revolution, socializing domestic work	Engels (1884), Alexandra Kollontai

School	Cause of oppression	Solution	Key thinkers and works
Socialist	Capitalism and patriarchy together	Change both economic and gender systems	Juliet Mitchell (Woman's Estate, 1971), Heidi Hartmann (1979)
Cultural	Devaluation of feminine qualities	Value women's ways (ethic of care)	Carol Gilligan, In a Different Voice (1982)
Eco	Domination of women and nature	Respect for nature and women, sustainable living	Françoise d'Eaubonne (coined the term, 1974), Vandana Shiva, Staying Alive (1988), Maria Mies
Postcolonial	Colonialism, racism and Western feminist bias	Listen to local women's voices, context-specific struggles	Chandra Talpade Mohanty, "Under Western Eyes" (1984); Gayatri Spivak, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988)
Postmodern	Fixed categories and language	Deconstruct gender binaries	Judith Butler (1990), Hélène Cixous, Luce Irigaray

Waves of feminism

Wave	Period	Focus
First	Mid-19th to early 20th century	Suffrage (right to vote), property rights, education, legal personhood
Second	1960s to 1980s	Workplace equality, reproductive rights, family, sexuality; "the personal is political"
Third	1990s to 2000s	Diversity, intersectionality, identity, challenging the second wave's focus on white middle-class women
Fourth	2010s onward	Digital activism, sexual harassment and violence (#MeToo, 2017), body positivity, online harassment

Feminism in India: reform-era concern with sati, widow remarriage and education; the freedom movement brought women into public life; after independence, the "Towards Equality" report (1974) revealed women's poor status; the 1970s–80s autonomous women's movement fought dowry deaths, custodial rape (Mathura case, 1972–1979) and for legal reforms.

Examples and comparisons

Example 1: Same problem, different schools. On the gender pay gap: liberal feminists push for equal pay laws (India's Equal Remuneration Act 1976, now part of the Code on Wages 2019); Marxist feminists link it to capitalism's need for cheap labour; radical feminists link it to male dominance of institutions; socialist feminists point to both, including unpaid care work at home.

Example 2: Ecofeminism in India. In the Chipko movement (Uttarakhand, 1973), village women hugged trees to stop commercial felling, because forests supplied their fuel, fodder and water. Vandana Shiva uses it to argue that women and nature are both exploited by development models.

Key points to remember

- Wollstonecraft 1792; Mill 1869; Friedan 1963; Millett and Firestone 1970; Gilligan 1982; Mohanty 1984; Spivak 1988; Butler 1990; Crenshaw 1989.
- Eight schools: liberal, radical, Marxist, socialist, cultural, eco, postcolonial, postmodern.
- Four waves: suffrage, equality and body, diversity, digital/#MeToo.
- Indian milestones: Towards Equality 1974; Mathura case; Chipko.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain the rise of feminism.
2. Explain liberal and radical feminism and compare them.
3. Explain Marxist and socialist feminism.
4. Explain cultural feminism and ecofeminism with examples.
5. Explain postcolonial and postmodern feminism.
6. Explain the waves of feminism.

NEXT ENGINEER _sheerat_

UNIT 3 Women's Movement

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Women's movement:** organized collective action by women (and supporters) to improve women's rights and status.
- **Suffrage:** the right to vote in political elections; suffragists campaigned peacefully, suffragettes (UK, Women's Social and Political Union, Emmeline Pankhurst) used militant methods.
- **Seneca Falls Convention (1848):** the first women's rights convention in the USA, organized by Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott, which adopted the Declaration of Sentiments.
- **Declaration of Sentiments:** the document modelled on the US Declaration of Independence, stating "all men and women are created equal" and listing grievances, including denial of the vote.
- **Social reform movement (India):** 19th and early 20th century efforts to end practices like sati, child marriage and the ban on widow remarriage, and to promote women's education.
- **Uniform Civil Code (UCC):** a single set of civil laws (marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption) for all citizens regardless of religion; Article 44 of the Indian Constitution (Directive Principle).
- **Shah Bano case (1985):** Supreme Court case (Mohd. Ahmed Khan v. Shah Bano Begum) that upheld a divorced Muslim woman's right to maintenance under Section 125 CrPC.
- **Double marginality (Dalit women):** Dalit women face discrimination both as women (gender) and as Dalits (caste), and often also class.

💡 Core concepts

Women in the Industrial Revolution: women and children worked long hours in textile mills and mines for lower wages than men; harsh, unsafe conditions; no vote or property rights for married women (coverture); the "double burden" of factory work plus household work. This exposure led to labour activism and the demand for rights.

Women's rights movement, 1848–1920 (USA, with UK parallels)

Year	Event
1848	Seneca Falls Convention, Declaration of Sentiments
1851	Sojourner Truth's speech "Ain't I a Woman?"
1869	National Woman Suffrage Association (Stanton, Susan B. Anthony) and American Woman Suffrage Association formed
1893	New Zealand becomes the first country to give women the vote
1903	Women's Social and Political Union founded in the UK
1918	UK gives the vote to women over 30 (with property qualifications)
1920	19th Amendment gives American women the right to vote

Year	Event
1928	UK gives equal voting rights at 21

Social reform movements in India

Reformer	Contribution
Raja Ram Mohan Roy	Campaign against sati; Bengal Sati Regulation 1829
Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar	Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act 1856; girls' schools
Jyotirao and Savitribai Phule	First girls' school in Pune (1848); Savitribai as India's first woman teacher; against caste and gender oppression
Pandita Ramabai	Arya Mahila Samaj; Sharada Sadan for widows; "The High-Caste Hindu Woman" (1887)
Tarabai Shinde	"Stri Purush Tulana" (1882), an early feminist critique
Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain	Muslim girls' education; "Sultana's Dream" (1905)
Behramji Malabari	Age of Consent Act 1891
Later laws	Child Marriage Restraint Act (Sarda Act) 1929

Women's groups and organizations: Women's Indian Association (1917, Annie Besant, Margaret Cousins), National Council of Women in India (1925), All India Women's Conference (1927); in the freedom struggle Sarojini Naidu, Kasturba Gandhi, Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, Aruna Asaf Ali, Captain Lakshmi Sehgal; after independence, SEWA (1972, Ela Bhatt), Saheli, Jagori, National Commission for Women (1992, statutory).

Uniform Civil Code and the Shah Bano case

- Shah Bano, a 62-year-old divorced woman, sought maintenance from her husband under Section 125 CrPC (a secular provision). The Supreme Court (1985) upheld her claim and said a UCC would promote national integration.
- After protests by some groups, Parliament passed the Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Divorce) Act 1986, which limited maintenance to the iddat period; women's groups criticized it.
- Danial Latifi v. Union of India (2001): the Supreme Court read the 1986 Act to require a fair and reasonable provision made within iddat, covering the woman's future.
- Later: Shayara Bano v. Union of India (2017) held instant triple talaq unconstitutional; Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Marriage) Act 2019; Uttarakhand adopted a state UCC in 2024.
- The debate: gender justice and equality (Articles 14, 15) vs freedom of religion (Article 25) and minority rights; many women's groups argue for gender-just reform within all personal laws.

Dalit women and double marginality: Dalit women face caste violence, sexual violence used to humiliate communities, untouchability, landlessness, low wages and exclusion from the mainstream women's movement, which was led mostly by upper-caste women. Dalit feminism (Gopal Guru's "Dalit Women Talk Differently", 1995; Sharmila Rege; National Federation of Dalit Women, 1995; Ruth Manorama) insists on intersectional analysis. Legal protection: SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act 1989 (amended 2015).

Examples and comparisons

Example 1: Phules' school. In 1848, the same year as Seneca Falls, Jyotirao and Savitribai Phule opened a school for girls in Pune. Savitribai was abused on her way to school but continued; this shows that in India the struggle for women's education was linked with the struggle against caste.

Example 2: Shah Bano timeline. 1978 divorce and claim → 1985 Supreme Court verdict for maintenance → 1986 Act limiting it → 2001 Danial Latifi reading in favour of fair provision → 2017 triple talaq judgment. It shows the tension between personal law, gender justice and politics.

Key points to remember

- 1848 Seneca Falls (Stanton, Mott); 1920 19th Amendment; New Zealand 1893 first vote.
- Indian reformers: Roy (1829), Vidyasagar (1856), Phules (1848), Ramabai, Rokeya; Sarda Act 1929.
- Organizations: WIA 1917, NCWI 1925, AIWC 1927, SEWA 1972, NCW 1992.
- Shah Bano 1985; 1986 Act; Danial Latifi 2001; Shayara Bano 2017; Article 44.
- Dalit women: double marginality; Gopal Guru 1995; NFDW 1995.

⭐ Important questions

1. Describe the socio-economic condition of women during the Industrial Revolution.
2. Explain the women's rights movement from 1848 to 1920.
3. Explain the historical development of social reform movements in India.
4. Explain the role of women's groups and organizations in India.
5. Explain the movement for a Uniform Civil Code and the Shah Bano case.
6. Explain the question of Dalit women and double marginality.

UNIT 4 Gender Roles and Psychology of Sex

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Gender role:** the set of behaviours, attitudes and activities a society considers appropriate for a person based on gender.
- **Gender role attitude:** a person's beliefs about what roles men and women should have; traditional (separate roles) or egalitarian (shared roles).
- **Gender stereotype:** an oversimplified, generalized belief about the characteristics of women or men ("women are emotional", "men don't cry").
- **Androgyny:** having both traditionally masculine and feminine traits; Sandra Bem's Sex Role Inventory (1974) measured it.
- **Social role theory:** sex differences in behaviour arise from the different social roles men and women occupy (Alice Eagly, 1987).
- **Gender similarities hypothesis:** men and women are similar on most psychological variables (Janet Hyde, 2005).
- **Trauma:** psychological harm from a deeply distressing event such as rape, abuse or violence.
- **Domestic violence:** physical, sexual, emotional or economic abuse by an intimate partner or family member.
- **Sexual harassment:** unwelcome sexually determined behaviour such as physical contact, demands for sexual favours, sexually coloured remarks, showing pornography, or any other unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature.
- **Eve teasing:** a South Asian euphemism for public sexual harassment of women (street harassment), now treated as a crime.

💡 Core concepts

Conceptualization of gender roles: gender roles are learned through socialization; they differ across cultures and change over time (more women in engineering, more men in childcare). Traditional roles cast men as breadwinners and women as homemakers; egalitarian attitudes support shared roles.

Gender differences (research summary)

Area	Findings
Aggression	Men show more physical aggression on average; women show similar or more relational (indirect) aggression; differences shaped by social norms
Achievement	Girls often do as well or better in school; gaps in some fields reflect stereotype threat, expectations and opportunities rather than ability
Communication	Women's speech often described as more rapport-oriented, men's more report-oriented (Deborah Tannen, 1990); overlaps are large
Friendship	Women's friendships more face-to-face and self-disclosing; men's more side-by-side, activity-based

Area	Findings
Romantic relationships	Expectations shaped by scripts; double standards about sexuality

Overall: most differences are small with large overlap (Hyde, 2005); social role, socialization and power explain much of them.

Sex differences in mental health: women report higher rates of depression and anxiety (about twice as common), eating disorders and PTSD; men have higher rates of substance abuse, antisocial behaviour and completed suicide. Causes: biological factors, social roles and stress (double burden), violence, help-seeking norms (men less likely to seek help).

Trauma related to sexual violence and abuse

- **Rape:** severe trauma, PTSD, depression, stigma and victim-blaming; taboo prevents reporting.
- **Childhood sexual abuse:** long-term effects on trust, mental health and relationships; POCSO Act 2012 protects children.
- **Domestic violence:** NFHS-5 (2019–21) found that about 3 in 10 ever-married women aged 18–49 had experienced physical or sexual violence by a husband; Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act 2005 gives civil remedies (protection orders, residence rights).
- **Support:** counselling, One Stop Centres (Sakhi), women's helpline 181, police help 112, legal aid.

Sexual harassment at workplaces and educational institutions

- Vishaka v. State of Rajasthan (1997): the Supreme Court laid down guidelines after the gang rape of Bhanwari Devi, a social worker, while trying to stop a child marriage.
- Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act 2013 (POSH Act): Internal Committee in every organization with 10 or more employees, Local Committee at district level, inquiry within 90 days.
- UGC Regulations 2015 for higher education institutions (Internal Complaints Committee).
- Criminal law: Criminal Law (Amendment) Act 2013 after the December 2012 Delhi gang rape (Nirbhaya) added offences of sexual harassment, stalking, voyeurism; these are now in the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023 (which replaced the IPC from July 2024).
- **Eve teasing:** street harassment covered under laws on sexual harassment, stalking and insulting the modesty of a woman; anti-Romeo squads and Shakti/She teams in some states.

Examples and comparisons

Example 1: Stereotype threat. When girls are told before a maths test that "boys usually score higher", their scores drop; when told the test shows no gender difference, the gap disappears. This shows achievement gaps can come from stereotypes, not ability.

Example 2: Internal Committee process. A student complains of harassment by a staff member. The college ICC (with a woman presiding officer and an external member) receives the written complaint within 3 months, inquires within 90 days, protects confidentiality and recommends action; interim relief (change of supervisor) can be given.

NEXT ENGINEER _sheerat_

Key points to remember

- Gender roles and attitudes (traditional vs egalitarian); Bem's androgyny (1974); Eagly's social role theory; Hyde's similarities hypothesis.
- Differences: aggression (physical vs relational), achievement (stereotype threat), communication (Tannen), friendship.
- Mental health: depression and anxiety higher in women; substance abuse and suicide higher in men.
- Laws: PWDVA 2005, POCSO 2012, POSH 2013, Vishaka 1997, Criminal Law Amendment 2013, BNS 2023.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain the conceptualization of gender roles and gender role attitudes.
2. Explain gender differences in aggression, achievement, communication, friendship and romantic relationships.
3. Explain sex differences in mental health.
4. Explain trauma related to rape, childhood sexual abuse and domestic violence.
5. Explain sexual harassment at workplaces and educational institutions and eve teasing, with the relevant laws.

NEXT ENGI
sheerat

UNIT 5 Gender and Representation

✍️ 2-mark definitions

- **Representation:** the way media and culture portray people, groups and ideas, which shapes how society sees them.
- **Stereotyping in media:** repeatedly showing a group in a fixed, simplified way (women as only homemakers or as objects of desire).
- **Male gaze:** the depiction of women from a heterosexual male viewpoint, as objects for male pleasure (Laura Mulvey, "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema", 1975).
- **Symbolic annihilation:** the absence, trivialization or condemnation of women in media (Gaye Tuchman, 1978).
- **Bechdel test:** a film passes if it has at least two named women who talk to each other about something other than a man (from Alison Bechdel's comic, 1985).
- **Objectification:** treating a person as a body or object rather than a full human being.
- **Mega serials (TV soaps):** long-running television dramas, often family-centred, that reach large audiences.
- **Feminist literary criticism:** reading literature to examine how it represents women and gender, and recovering women writers.

💡 Core concepts

Gender and print media: fewer women as sources, experts and bylines; women's issues pushed to "lifestyle" pages; sensational reporting of violence; victim-blaming language; the Press Council of India has norms against identifying rape survivors. The Global Media Monitoring Project repeatedly finds women are only about a quarter of people heard or read about in the news.

Gender and electronic media: television news and debates with few women experts; reality shows with stereotyped roles; social media with both empowerment (#MeToo, online campaigns) and harassment (trolling, deepfakes, cyberstalking); algorithms that reinforce beauty standards.

Gender and films: heroines as decorative or as "item numbers"; hero-centred narratives; stalking shown as romance; the male gaze; pay gaps between actors. Changes: women-centred films (Mother India, Mirch Masala, Arth, Queen, Pink, Thappad, The Great Indian Kitchen) question patriarchy; more women directors and writers.

Advertisements and mega serials: ads show women mostly in homes using detergents and cooking products, or as glamour objects to sell cars and deodorants; fairness cream ads linked fair skin to success (the 2020 rename of "Fair and Lovely" to "Glow and Lovely" followed criticism). Serials often show the ideal "sanskari bahu", scheming women as villains, joint family conflicts and regressive practices; some newer series show working women and shared roles. ASCI (Advertising Standards Council of India) guidelines (2022) discourage harmful gender stereotypes.

Stereotyping and breaking norms: stereotypes: women as weak, emotional, dependent, beauty-focused; men as strong, unemotional, breadwinners. Breaking norms: ads with men doing housework

(the "Share the Load" campaign), women in sports films (Dangal, Chak De! India), women engineers and astronauts in media, gender-neutral toy ads.

Women's representation in literary texts: traditional epics and classics often show idealized women (Sita as the ideal wife) or as causes of conflict; women writers and feminist critics present women's inner lives, resistance and diversity. Indian examples: Ismat Chughtai ("Lihaaf", 1942), Mahasweta Devi ("Draupadi", 1978), Kamala Das ("An Introduction"), Mahadevi Varma ("Shrinkhala ki Kadiyan"), Amrita Pritam ("Pinjar"), Shashi Deshpande ("That Long Silence", 1988), Bama ("Karukku", 1992, a Dalit woman's voice). Western: Virginia Woolf ("A Room of One's Own", 1929), Charlotte Perkins Gilman ("The Yellow Wallpaper", 1892), Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar ("The Madwoman in the Attic", 1979), Elaine Showalter (gynocriticism).

Examples and comparisons

Example 1: Applying the Bechdel test. In a typical romantic film, the heroine talks to her friend only about the hero: fails. In "Queen" (2014), Rani talks with Vijayalakshmi about travel, work and independence: passes. The test is simple and does not judge quality, but it shows how often women's stories revolve around men.

Example 2: Ad analysis. A detergent ad shows the mother scrubbing stains while the father reads the newspaper; message: laundry is women's work. The "Share the Load" ad shows a father realizing he never helped and starting to do laundry; message: domestic work should be shared. Same product, opposite gender messages.

Key points to remember

- Mulvey's male gaze (1975); Tuchman's symbolic annihilation (1978); Bechdel test (1985).
- Print: few women sources and experts; victim-blaming language.
- Electronic and social media: empowerment and online harassment.
- Films and serials: item numbers, stalking as romance, sanskari bahu; changing trends.
- Ads: domestic and glamour roles; fairness creams; ASCI 2022 guidelines; Share the Load.
- Literature: Chughtai, Mahasweta Devi, Kamala Das, Bama, Woolf, Gilbert and Gubar.

⭐ Important questions

1. Explain gender representation in print and electronic media.
2. Explain gender in films with examples.
3. Explain the representation of women in advertisements and mega serials.
4. Explain stereotyping and breaking norms of women's roles in media.
5. Explain women's representation in literary texts.

Last-hour checklist

- ☐ Sex vs gender (de Beauvoir 1949, Oakley 1972); institutions; theories of gender construction table.

NEXT ENGINEER _sheerat_

☐ Sexism, androcentrism; patriarchy theories (Engels, Millett, Hartmann, Walby, Lerner, Chakravarti); public-private; sexual division of labour; textbooks.

☐ Rise of feminism (Wollstonecraft, Mill); eight schools table; four waves; intersectionality (Crenshaw 1989).

☐ Industrial Revolution; 1848–1920 timeline; Indian reformers table; organizations; Shah Bano and UCC timeline; Dalit women.

☐ Gender roles, Bem, Eagly, Hyde; differences table; mental health; trauma; laws (PWDVA, POCSO, POSH, Vishaka, BNS).

☐ Media: print, electronic, films, ads, serials; male gaze; Bechdel; stereotypes and breaking norms; literature list.

Books prescribed by AKTU

These are the books named in the official AKTU syllabus. Buy or borrow them through a bookshop or your college library. The WorldCat links show which libraries hold a copy.

#	Title	Author(s)	Publisher	Where to get it legally
1	Women's Studies: Various Aspects	Basabi Chakrabarti	Urbi Prakashan (2014)	WorldCat
2	Queer: Despised Sexuality, Law and Social Change	Arvind Narrain	Books for Change (2004)	WorldCat
3	Feminism without Borders: Decolonizing Theory, Practicing Solidarity	Chandra Talpade Mohanty	Duke University Press	WorldCat
4	Law and Gender Inequality: The Politics of Women's Rights in India	Flavia Agnes	Oxford University Press (2001)	WorldCat
5	Women, Democracy and the Media: Cultural and Political Representations in the Indian Press	Sonia Bathla	Sage, New Delhi (1998)	WorldCat

The syllabus notes that this course should be taught by faculty who have completed the relevant faculty development programme.

Syllabus source: AKTU Open Elective syllabus for B.Tech final year, 2025-26 (copy hosted by an affiliated college, PDF)